

A FIELD GUIDE FOR HOME SERVICE BUSINESSES

WHO SHOWS UP FIRST?

Find out whether Al search already picked your competitor over you — and exactly what to do about it, this week, with tools you already have.



YOU, RIGHT NOW



THEM, IF NOTHING CHANGES

THE JOB NOBODY TOLD YOU ABOUT

Your next customer isn't scrolling anymore. They're asking.

A homeowner with a leaking water heater doesn't type a search and read ten links anymore. More and more, they open ChatGPT or Google and type something closer to a real question — *"who's a good emergency plumber near me right now"* — and get back one direct answer. One name, one number. If that name isn't yours, you don't lose the job. You never even know it existed.

~1 IN 100

LOCAL BUSINESSES ACTUALLY GOT NAMED, IN ONE LARGE-SCALE 2026 TEST OF AI RECOMMENDATIONS

1 IN 4

EVERYDAY GOOGLE SEARCHES NOW SHOW AN AI-WRITTEN ANSWER ABOVE THE NORMAL RESULTS

84%

OF CONSUMERS SAY THEY LOOK UP LOCAL BUSINESSES ONLINE EVERY SINGLE DAY

Here's the part that should make you angry, not anxious: showing up in these answers has very little to do with who does better work. It has to do with whose information the AI can read clearly and trust confidently. Two equally good companies can get two completely different outcomes — and most owners have no idea which side of that line they're on.

The good news is this isn't a reason to hire an agency or learn to code. Most of what makes a business "AI visible" is the same groundwork that's always mattered for local search — a complete, accurate profile and a website that actually answers the question — just aimed a little differently. That's what the rest of this guide walks through, in plain language, with nothing to install.

ONE HONEST CAVEAT

Nobody — including anyone who tries to sell you a guaranteed ranking — can promise a specific spot in a system that regenerates its answers on the fly. The goal here isn't a score you hit once. It's a short list of habits you check monthly, because the businesses that stay visible are the ones who keep checking.

01

Find Out Where You Actually Stand

Before you fix anything, see exactly what AI tools are already telling customers about your business — and who they're naming instead.



SECTION 01 · THE SELF-AUDIT

Run your own audit in about 15 minutes

No software, no signup. Just three tabs and the same questions your customers are already asking.

- 1 Open ChatGPT, Perplexity, and Google in three separate tabs.** Use a private or incognito window in each so old searches and saved history don't quietly skew the answer.
- 2 Ask the way a real customer would.** Not your business name — the actual need: "emergency HVAC repair in [your city]," "best roofer near [your neighborhood]," "who should I call for a clogged main line."
- 3 Read the whole answer, not just the first line.** Is your business named at all? Is it first, or buried under two competitors? Is a specific competitor named instead of you?
- 4 Check accuracy, not just presence.** Right phone number, right service area, right hours. A wrong detail can lose you the call even in the answer that does mention you.
- 5 Repeat this in a few days.** AI answers shift from one run to the next — that's normal. One great result isn't proof, and one bad result isn't a verdict. You're looking for a pattern across a week, not a single snapshot.

WHERE TO START

Begin with Perplexity if you've never done this before — it lists its source links directly beside every answer, so you can see exactly which website or directory listing it pulled your (or your competitor's) information from. ChatGPT and Google's AI answers are worth checking too, since your customers may not all use the same one.

SECTION 01 · READY-MADE PROMPTS

Copy these in, swap the brackets, hit enter

▶ THE DIRECT ASK

"Who is the best [your trade] in [your city]?"

▶ THE EMERGENCY ASK

"I need an emergency [your trade] near [your neighborhood] right now — who should I call?"

▶ THE COMPARISON ASK

"Compare [Your Business Name] and [Competitor Name] for [service] in [city]."

▶ THE FOLLOW-UP ASK

"Why did you recommend them instead of other options?"

Fill in the scorecard below as you go — it only takes a minute per platform, and Section 2 builds directly on what you find here.

PLATFORM	MENTIONED?	POSITION	INFO ACCURATE?
ChatGPT			
Perplexity			
Google AI Overview			

02

See What They're Seeing In Your Competitor

If AI is naming someone else, it isn't because they're older or bigger. It's because their information is easier to trust. Here's how to find out what they're doing right.



SECTION 02 · REVERSE-ENGINEERING THE ANSWER

Ask the AI why it picked them

When a competitor gets named instead of you, don't close the tab. Ask a follow-up in that same conversation: *"what makes them a good choice?"* or *"what do customers say about them?"* The answer usually points straight at what to go copy.

It's tempting to assume a competitor wins these answers because they've been around longer or run a bigger operation. The research doesn't back that up. Testing on a brand-new business with zero track record found it could still earn AI citations within weeks — once its information was structured clearly and stayed consistent everywhere it appeared. In other words: this is about clarity and trust signals, not tenure. It's genuinely fixable at any size.

LOOK FOR THESE THREE THINGS IN THEIR PRESENCE

- ☐ **Review volume and recency** — do they have noticeably more reviews, or a steadier stream of recent ones, than you do?
- ☐ **Specific language in those reviews** — do customers name the exact service and neighborhood, rather than just "great job, thanks"?
- ☐ **Plain, specific service listings** — is their website or profile describing "tankless water heater installation" instead of just "plumbing services"?

WHY THIS IS WORTH DOING EVEN IF YOUR GOOGLE RANKING LOOKS FINE

Independent research comparing traditional rankings against AI answers found that fewer than half of the businesses ranking well in ordinary local search also showed up when the same categories were tested inside AI tools. Ranking well on Google and getting recommended by AI turned out to be two separate contests — which means this section is worth doing on its own, not just once your SEO is "done."

03

Fix What AI Can't See

Most AI visibility problems trace back to the same handful of gaps.
None of them require a developer, an agency, or a budget.



1 GOOGLE BUSINESS PROFILE

It's doing double duty now — treat it that way

Your free Google Business Profile no longer just feeds Google Maps. It's one of the main sources AI tools pull from when they decide what to say about you. It's also the single highest-leverage fix on this whole list, and it costs nothing.

- ☐ **Name matches real life.** Your listing name matches your actual signage and paperwork exactly — no city names or keywords tacked on.
- ☐ **The most specific category available is selected.** This consistently shows up as the single biggest lever you control — "printer repair shop" outperforms "computer shop" every time it's genuinely more accurate.
- ☐ **Name, address, and phone number match, character for character,** across your website, this profile, and every directory you appear on.
- ☐ **Every service is listed individually** with a real one- or two-line description — not just a category left on its default.
- ☐ **Photos are real job photos,** uploaded regularly. Skip stock imagery entirely — authentic, current photos consistently outperform it.
- ☐ **Reviews arrive steadily,** not in one big burst followed by silence, and you reply to every single one.
- ☐ **You post an update roughly once a week** — a finished job, a seasonal reminder, anything that shows the profile is actively managed.

2 YOUR WEBSITE

Give AI an answer it can lift directly

AI tools favor content that answers the question immediately, in plain language, near the top of the page — not three paragraphs of branding before the actual answer shows up.

Add a direct-answer block to your top pages. At the very top of each core service page, put two or three plain sentences that answer the exact question a customer would type — "How much does a water heater replacement cost in [city]?" gets answered immediately, then explained further below it.

Add a short FAQ section to every service page. Four or five real questions is plenty. Most website builders — Wix, Squarespace, WordPress — have a built-in FAQ block or a free plugin that formats these so both AI tools and Google can read them cleanly. You don't need to touch any code to do this.

Say your service area and hours the same way, everywhere on the site. A mismatch between your footer and your contact page creates the same trust problem, on a smaller scale, as a mismatch across the wider web.

IF "SCHEMA MARKUP" COMES UP ANYWHERE

That's just a technical label for tagging a question as a question and an answer as an answer, so a machine doesn't have to guess. If your website platform's FAQ block handles this automatically — and most do now — you never need to see the code behind it.

3 DIRECTORIES & CONSISTENCY

Close the small gaps that undermine trust

AI tools cross-check several sources before deciding what to say about a business. One outdated listing can quietly cancel out an otherwise great website.

- ☐ **Claim and complete your profile** on whichever directories your trade actually uses — Yelp, Angi, Thumbtack, Nextdoor, HomeAdvisor, or the Better Business Bureau. You don't need all of them, just the ones your customers actually check.
- ☐ **Search your own business name plus your city** and fix anything showing the wrong hours, an old address, or a duplicate listing you forgot existed.
- ☐ **If you belong to a Chamber of Commerce or trade association**, make sure that listing is current too — these carry real trust weight with almost no effort to maintain.
- ☐ **Recheck this list every few months.** Outdated information never announces itself. It just quietly costs you the call.

04

Keep Score

This isn't a one-time project. AI visibility drifts the same way local rankings always have — the businesses that stay visible are the ones who keep checking.



SECTION 04 · PUT IT ON THE CALENDAR

One small job per day

DAY

1

Run the self-audit across all three platforms. Fill in your **scorecard** from Section 1.

DAY

2

Fix your **Google Business Profile** name and category — the single biggest lever you control.

DAY

3

Check name/address/phone **consistency** across your website, profile, and three directories.

DAY

4

Add a **direct-answer block** to your homepage and your top service page.

DAY

5

Add a short **FAQ section** to your top two service pages.

DAY

6

Ask three recent customers for a review that names the specific **service and neighborhood**.

DAY

7

Re-run the Section 01 prompts and compare the answers against **Day 1**.

BEFORE YOU GO

This is the floor, not the ceiling

Working through everything in this guide won't guarantee a first-place answer every time someone asks — treat anyone who promises that with real suspicion. What it does is close the gaps that most of your competitors haven't bothered to close yet. Most of the time, that's enough to flip who gets named.

Put a fifteen-minute recheck on your calendar once a month: same three prompts, same scorecard, same eye for what changed. AI answers move on their own schedule, not yours — the only real defense is noticing before it costs you a season of calls.

WANT THE DEEPER VERSION?

A full personalized audit across every platform — or ongoing monthly tracking so you're not doing this by hand — is available as a next step. *[add your contact info / link here]*



RECHECK MONTHLY. THAT'S THE WHOLE SYSTEM.